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The Acceleration of Artificial Intelligence: Rethinking Organization and Work in an Era of Rapid Technological Change

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ABSTRACT Artificial intelligence (AI) is transforming the epistemic, interactional, and institutional foundations of contemporary organizations, yet management and organization studies are only beginning to theorise the implications of this shift. Existing research often treats "AI" as a singular construct, despite the fact that predictive, generative, agentic, and embodied systems rely on different logics and produce distinct organizational outcomes. This article interrogates the limits of this conceptual flattening and argues that cumulative theorising requires more precise specification of the technological systems under study. Drawing on developments across the field, we demonstrate how different modes of AI reshape core organizational constructs, including expertise, judgement, coordination, authority, and institutional adaptation. We advance a heuristic framework that differentiates among contemporary AI systems and clarifies their distinct affordances. The article concludes by outlining a research agenda that focusses on the shifting loci of agency, new decision architectures, and the normative and institutional challenges introduced by increasingly powerful AI systems.

Keywords: artificial intelligence, entrepreneurship, future of work, labour, strategy

INTRODUCTION

Humans find exponentials difficult to comprehend (Ciccione et al., 2022). In organizational contexts, this cognitive limitation helps explain the growing gap between the pace of advances in artificial intelligence (AI) and the ability of organizations, institutions, and theories to accommodate them. Technologies that only recently appeared experimental

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have become embedded in everyday organizational practice. Little more than a decade ago, researchers highlighted the significance of AI systems that could identify a cat in a photograph (Krizhevsky et al., 2012; Le et al., 2013). Today, a single line of text can generate a dynamic three-dimensional environment (e.g., Google's Genie 3), compose an original piece of music (Chayka, 2025), or even front a primetime television programme (Heritage, 2025). The adoption of these large language models (LLMs) has already outpaced the diffusion of the internet (Bick et al., 2024), and tools that were peripheral novelties are now becoming central to organizational life. The speed and scope of this transformation have caught firms, governments, and scholars unprepared. As commentators have noted, AI is driving a reorganization of work (Acemoglu and Restrepo, 2019; Yee, 2024) whose pace increasingly challenges the adaptive capacity of existing organization and management theory to make sense of it.

As we approach 3 years since the release of ChatGPT 3.5 (November 2022), often viewed as the first mainstream generative AI system (i.e., a subcategory of contemporary AI systems designed to produce novel synthetic outputs across text, image, audio, and other modalities), it is an opportune moment to consider how this technology is reshaping work, organization, and management. Its effects have been pervasive, though uneven. For decades, white-collar professions were widely regarded as insulated from automation, protected by the tacit, interpretive, and interpersonal character of their work. That assumption has eroded rapidly. In the 'jagged frontier' (Dell'Aqua et al., 2023) of medical practice, diagnostic systems now approach clinician-level performance in some tasks (Shen et al., 2019; Takita et al., 2025), while in the business world, LLM-based assistants can already produce reports, market summaries, and strategic analyses that were previously drafted by teams of junior analysts. As various online memes now ask, *why pay a Big Four consultancy six-figure fees when an intern with ChatGPT can generate comparable outputs for $20 a month?* Like most humour, the joke contains a painful truth: the scale of potential disruption to knowledge work is profound and unsettling. McKinsey Global Institute (2023) estimates that up to 30 per cent of work hours in the US economy could be automated by 2030, while Goldman Sachs (2023) suggests that roughly 44 per cent of legal-profession tasks – central to the professional-services sector – are technically automatable with current LLM capabilities. Taken together, these forecasts indicate that generative AI reaches deep into the heart of knowledge work in ways without historical precedent.

Yet perhaps the most visible implications of AI are generational. For younger workers and graduates, 2025 has marked a decisive shift in the trajectory of early career development. Across Western economies, major employers in consulting, accounting and financial services have significantly reduced graduate intakes as they reengineer workflows around AI-enabled automation (Llewellyn Smith, 2025). Routine analytical tasks that once provided formative training for junior staff – data cleaning, report preparation and compliance reviews – are increasingly delegated to AI systems. This contraction echoes emerging evidence from online labour platforms, where workers in AI-exposed, routine writing and analytical roles have experienced significant short-term declines in employment and earnings (Hui et al., 2024). Labour-market analyses also point to a rapid shift toward skills-based rather than credential-based hiring (Bone et al., 2025), which holds implications for those who provide 'traditional' education pathways. As

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entry points narrow, opportunities for skill development, mentorship, career progression and workplace socialization diminish. From a theoretical perspective therefore, AI is reshaping both the content of work *and* the deeper structures through which professions are learned, reproduced and rewarded.

Such transformations invite renewed questions about authority, legitimacy, and the broader meaning of organizational life. As AI systems generate knowledge, make recommendations, and evaluate performance, they no longer merely support decision processes but actively participate in the symbolic and epistemic foundations of organizing (Alaimo and Kallinikos, 2021; Faraj et al., 2018; Pachidi et al., 2021). Building on earlier work on sociomateriality (Leonardi, 2011; Orlikowski, 2007), recent studies show how algorithms act as 'partners' in organizational life (Siemon et al., 2026), reshaping categories of judgment and conferring new forms of authority and legitimacy (Lindebaum et al., 2024). AI thus heightens the recursive interplay between material artefacts and institutional meaning-making, introducing agents that, in addition to executing tasks, also contribute to defining the problems organizations seek to solve (Raisch and Fomina, 2025). These developments require conceptual frameworks capable of keeping pace with a technology that unsettles deeply embedded epistemic norms (Grimes et al., 2023; Kulkarni et al., 2024) and, at a meta level, have prompted journals and the scholarly community to articulate new principles for the responsible use of AI in research and publishing (Gatrell et al., 2024).

Amid this turbulence, research on AI and organizing has proliferated with speed and creativity. The response to our *Journal of Management Studies* Special Issue, *Artificial intelligence: Organizational possibilities and pitfalls*, exceeded all expectations. What stood out was not only the volume of submissions (among the highest in the journal's history) but also the conceptual diversity and methodological innovation they exhibited. Across the accepted articles, contributors deploy problematising review (Ramaul et al., 2026), comparative field studies of AI-mediated expertise and authority (Mayer et al., 2026), computational analyses of algorithmic judgment and organizational decision-making in financial services and corporate governance (Hudson and Morgan, 2026; Lee et al., 2026), and experimental investigations of social presence and emotional responses in human–AI collaboration (Siemon et al., 2026; Vuori et al., 2026). Other contributions examine the behavioural and ethical dynamics of human–AI collaboration (He et al., 2026) and offer theoretical reflections on the interpretive and methodological challenges of studying AI in organizational settings (Huysman, 2026). Taken together, these contributions show how AI is reshaping organizing across areas as varied as financial services, corporate governance, strategy and creative work. Collectively, these 14 articles depict a field in rapid formation – empirically rich, methodologically plural and marked by the kind of conceptual fragmentation that is characteristic of a nascent research domain still discovering its boundaries.

To integrate insights from these contributions and to reflect on the broader progress of the field, this paper advances four aims. First, we take stock of the rapidly expanding literature on AI and organizing, identifying four major strands of scholarship that delineate the contours of this emerging field: research on AI in the workplace, AI and strategic management, AI and entrepreneurship, and AI and ethics. Second, we interrogate what is meant by 'AI' itself. The term now functions as a broad umbrella,

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encompassing systems that vary markedly in capability, autonomy, and organizational consequence. Such conceptual looseness risks theoretical drift and slows cumulative theorizing. To address this, we propose a scoping framework that distinguishes among *predictive*, *generative*, *agentic*, and *embodied* forms of AI, providing a foundation for greater conceptual precision. Third, we provide an overview of the articles in our special issue, drawing out some of the most important new contributions to our understanding of AI and organization. Finally, we set out an agenda for future research. Building on insights from this issue, we identify conceptual, methodological, and ethical opportunities for understanding how AI continues to reshape work, organizing, and management theory.

SITUATING THE FIELD: A NARRATIVE REVIEW OF THE LITERATURE

Although AI is not new to organizational research, its rapid development and widespread accessibility – particularly of generative systems and large language models – have triggered an exponential growth in scholarship. Since 2022, when this Special Issue was launched, at least five impactful literature reviews on AI in organizations have appeared (e.g., Bankins et al., 2024; Basu et al., 2023; Hillebrand et al., 2025; Karunakaran et al., 2025; Pereira et al., 2023). Whereas interest in organizational AI was once concentrated in management science and information systems, today virtually every subfield of business and management studies engages with the topic. We synthesize key developments in this rapidly expanding domain through four themes that emerged from our narrative review: (a) AI in the workplace, (b) AI and strategic management, (c) AI and entrepreneurship, and (d) AI and ethics.

AI in the Workplace

Most research on AI in the workplace has examined human–AI collaboration, AI-enabled control and surveillance, and the effects of AI on everyday work practices.

*Human–*AI *collaboration*. Effective human–AI collaboration is generally achieved when AI complements or augments employee skills rather than replaces or automates them (Bankins et al., 2024; Raisch and Krakowski, 2021). However, research in knowledge-intensive settings shows that automation and augmentation often blur in practice (Einola and Khoreva, 2023). Several factors support successful collaboration, including satisfaction with the technology, strong task-technology fit, higher trust in AI, greater understanding of the system, and the presence of AI-relevant skills (Chowdhury et al., 2022; Nguyen and Malik, 2022; Sowa et al., 2021).

Positive outcomes have been observed when AI adoption reshapes job design and expands employee resources. Increases in innovative behaviour, creativity, and reduced fatigue occur when AI enhances job autonomy, specialization, and complexity (Qiu et al., 2022; Verma and Singh, 2022), particularly among highly skilled employees (Jia et al., 2024). However, studies have identified an inverted U-shaped relationship between expertise and AI-enabled performance, in which only workers with moderate levels of expertise benefit from collaboration with AI (Allen and Choudhury, 2022; Luo

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et al., 2021). This pattern likely reflects algorithmic aversion among experts and information overload among novices, although involving employees in algorithm design can partially mitigate aversion (Kawaguchi, 2021). Algorithmic aversion, reduced trust in AI-generated advice, and heightened concerns about job displacement can also help explain why employees respond negatively when managers use AI-generated assessments in performance feedback (Tong et al., 2021).

AI-*enabled control and surveillance*. The rise of platform-based work, which involves labour processes and employment relations that differ markedly from traditional forms of work (Curchod et al., 2020), has spurred substantial research on AI-enabled control and surveillance (Bankins et al., 2024; Heiland, 2022; Huang, 2023; Waldkirch et al., 2021). Working under algorithmic management has been shown to constrain employee agency and amplify power asymmetries (Curchod et al., 2020; Hillebrand et al., 2025), effects that are intensified by the opacity of algorithmic decision processes (Lavanchy et al., 2023). Beyond platform-based gig work, organizations increasingly deploy AI for algorithmic monitoring and performance management, comparing real-time behavioural data against normative expectations for work processes (Kellogg et al., 2020; Leonardi, 2021; Qin et al., 2023; see also Tong et al., 2021 already discussed earlier).

The impact of AI on work practices. Whether AI is introduced to automate tasks and remove humans from the loop or to augment existing work (Raisch and Krakowski, 2021), work practices are significantly reshaped. The introduction of generative AI often leads to the reconfiguration of work roles, such as shifting workers from content creation toward editing and reviewing (Retkowsky et al., 2024). AI tools also embody distinct ontological assumptions that reshape organizational knowledge production, potentially altering which forms of knowledge are valued and how expertise is recognized (Pachidi et al., 2021). As a result, professionals frequently find themselves questioning and revising established practices of judgment and decision-making when interacting with AI systems (Lebovitz et al., 2022).

Employee attitudes toward workplace AI, including perceived human-likeness, adaptability, quality, personal utility, AI-related anxiety and job insecurity, can help explain how AI-enabled work practices can be designed for positive outcomes (Park et al., 2024). The difficulty of understanding how AI tools operate or justify their recommendations, particularly given their inherent opacity (Anthony, 2021), underscores the need for close collaboration between domain experts and AI developers (Pachidi and Huysman, 2024; van den Broek et al., 2021). Opacity also elevates the role of knowledge brokers who translate, contextualize, or supplement AI outputs with their own judgment (Waardenburg et al., 2022).

AI and Strategic Management

AI and decision-making. As AI enables pattern detection and analysis across large and heterogeneous datasets, scholars have begun to consider whether it could help organizations approach the long-elusive ideal of rational decision-making (Pachidi and

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Huysman, 2017). AI tools now support managers by enabling them to analyse competition, model customer responses, explore strategic alternatives and business models, and frame complex decisions (Hillebrand et al., 2025; Olenick and Zemsky, 2023; Ramge and Mayer-Schönberger, 2023). Although these perspectives adopt a largely capability-focused and positivist orientation, other research highlights the challenges that arise when organizations rely on AI systems for decisions.

While AI-generated information can deepen managerial understanding of organizational environments, the ontological assumptions embedded in algorithms may constrain organizational learning and produce new forms of myopia (Pachidi and Huysman, 2017). Increased reliance on AI can also inhibit the development of tacit, contextual, and intuitive knowledge that managers depend upon when making judgments (Balasubramanian et al., 2022).

Scholars have also examined the conditions under which managers develop trust in AI recommendations. From a design perspective, features such as tangibility, transparency, reliability, and anthropomorphism were suggested to shape the development of cognitive trust in AI for decision-making (Glikson and Woolley, 2020). From a more human-centred perspective, trust is influenced by perceptions of AI agency that emerge through interaction with the tool (Jones, 2025; Vanneste and Puranam, 2025), as well as by agency attributed to the technology by influential organizational actors (Leonardi, 2025). At the same time, overreliance on AI risks distancing decision makers from the contextual and temporal knowledge that supports sound judgment (Bader and Kaiser, 2019).

Changing rules of strategy. To an unprecedentedly high degree, organizations of all sizes from all sorts of industries are currently racing to keep up – or even leverage and sustain – the AI hype (Logue and Grimes, 2022). AI is often approached by managers and strategy consultants as a capability enabling firms to accomplish new forms of competitive advantage by enabling diversification of portfolios, scaling up and improvements of operations, cost efficiencies through increased productivity, or by turning data in and of itself into a source of competitive advantage (Barro and Davenport, 2019; Davenport and Ronanki, 2018; Tarafdar et al., 2019). Strategy scholars cannot easily avoid the bandwagon of exploring AI's presumed promise for competitive advantage (Kemp, 2024) and developing playbooks and steps toward formulating an 'effective' AI business strategy (Hutzschenreuter and Lämmermann, 2025). A critical challenge that executives reportedly face as they try to strategize with and for AI concerns its dynamically changing nature, which requires constant anticipatory work and pivoting toward a moving technological target (Berente et al., 2021; Hutzschenreuter and Lämmermann, 2025).

Critical responses to technologically deterministic perspectives urge scholars to attend more closely to the assumptions and social values embedded in AI design (Moser et al., 2024). Recognizing the agency of technology through frameworks such as sociomateriality (Orlikowski, 2007; Orlikowski and Scott, 2008), human technology assemblages (Glaser et al., 2021; Omidvar et al., 2023), conjoined agency (Fisher and Fleming, 2025; Murray et al., 2021), and embodied realities (Newlands, 2020) supports more nuanced accounts of how AI's organizational effects emerge through

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situated interactions between technologies, professionals, and organizational contexts (Lindebaum et al., 2023). This line of work draws attention to the sociotechnical construction of data objects, showing how organizational and environmental orders are reshaped when data become the primary medium of value capture and exchange (Alaimo and Kallinikos, 2021). It also highlights how firms that operate through models of data extractivism use AI to collect and process vast quantities of user data in exchange for ostensibly free or low-cost services (Sadowski, 2019). These practices produce new power asymmetries, as large technology firms leverage extensive data access to predict and influence user behaviour, entrenching competitive advantage and transforming economic systems within what Zuboff (2019) describes as surveillance capitalism.

AI and Entrepreneurship

AI for exploration. Early work on AI and entrepreneurship raised foundational questions about whether organizations could rely on intelligent systems for exploratory problem solving (von Krogh, 2018). Recent research indicates that firms now draw on AI to address exploratory challenges through several distinct modes, including sequential search, where AI explores the problem space before humans pursue solution pathways; autonomous search, where AI defines problems and proposes solutions that humans subsequently evaluate; and interactive search, where humans and AI jointly engage in exploration (Raisch and Fomina, 2025). Across these modes, researchers and practitioners are experimenting with different AI tools to generate novelty and support open-ended innovation (Shepherd and Majchrzak, 2022). Experimental evidence suggests that human-GenAI collaboration in early innovation stages can outperform human-only problem solving, producing solutions with greater strategic viability, value, and quality while improving scalability and cost-effectiveness in the innovation process (Boussioux et al., 2024). Yet the affordances of AI in innovation remain contingent, emerging from situated assemblages of humans, technologies, data, and artefacts (Gehman et al., 2025). A further constraint is the assumption of environmental predictability. Many AI techniques presuppose futures that are computable from past and present data, whereas entrepreneurs routinely operate under Knightian uncertainty that resists algorithmic specification (Townsend et al., 2024, 2025). This tension highlights both the promise and the limits of AI for entrepreneurial exploration, suggesting that its impact will vary with the nature of the uncertainty confronting entrepreneurial actors.

AI for new value creation. AI developments have enabled firms to create value in new ways, including augmenting existing products with algorithmic capabilities, shifting toward personalized service models, and designing new value propositions grounded in data and machine learning (Benbya et al., 2021; Berente et al., 2021; Chalmers et al., 2021; Shepherd and Majchrzak, 2022). Digital platforms exemplify this shift by generating data network effects that allow services to be progressively individualized as user data accumulates (Gregory et al., 2021). The rapid rise of GenAI, and its perceived capacity to automate a wide range of cognitive tasks, is also prompting professional service firms to reconsider business models that rely on billable hours. As a result, firms are exploring how GenAI can support

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alternative models of value creation (Berg et al., 2023). Implementing GenAI, however, comes with substantial organizational challenges. It often requires changes to structure, culture, and everyday processes, including the creation of new roles for GenAI governance, the development of content-review routines, and enhanced risk-management procedures for bias, copyright and ethical concerns (Campbell et al., 2025). More broadly, AI adoption is prompting firms to consider not only economic returns but also the psychological, social, political and environmental consequences of their innovations (Amabile, 2020), pushing value creation into a wider set of societal concerns.

AI and Ethics

The rapid expansion of AI in organizational settings has produced a growing literature on the ethical implications of its design, deployment and governance (Berente et al., 2021). While concerns about deskilling and job displacement remain salient, scholars have also highlighted broader ethical challenges, including data privacy, accountability and the evolving regulatory frameworks that govern algorithmic systems (Jobin et al., 2019; Smuha, 2021). These challenges are amplified by the reliance of contemporary AI models on large, distributed datasets that often integrate proprietary and publicly accessible sources (Berente et al., 2021). Such data infrastructures raise questions about consent, ownership and the uneven distribution of risks and benefits across user groups. In what follows, we examine the ethical landscape through two lenses: the mechanization of values in algorithmic systems and the wider ethical considerations arising from AI's increasing role in organizational life.

Mechanization of Values. Algorithmic management can lead to the mechanization of values, defined in terms of the translation of diverse societal norms into forms that privilege rationality (Lindebaum et al., 2023). Because contemporary AI systems are trained on vast datasets, their deployment often produces gains in efficiency and innovation (Agrawal et al., 2022, cited in van den Broek, 2025). Yet many systems are built in ways that implicitly prioritize efficiency above other organizational or moral considerations (Lindebaum et al., 2023, p. 66), a concern that becomes especially acute when human actors struggle to override AI-generated recommendations (see also Mayer et al., this issue). Moser et al. (2022) warn that AI-generated outputs reflect algorithmic reckoning rooted in computational rationality rather than human judgment. Their main argument is that increasing reliance on algorithmic reckoning in our decision-making, potentially substituting such reckoning for human judgment, risks eroding human morality (i.e., how to act appropriately in a given context). Although there are debates on AI design embedding diverse values into the programming, training, and use of AI systems, ultimately the onus of responsible use of AI is on AI programmers and developers and AI systems' users (Moser et al., 2022; see also Hagtvedt et al., 2025 for an excellent study on how AI creators navigate moral consequences of their work). Governance frameworks emphasizing integrity, clarity of responsibility and liability, and mechanisms such as whistleblowing have become increasingly common in response to these challenges (Jobin et al., 2019).

Other Ethical Considerations. Beyond questions of values, morality and governance structures, a substantial body of scholarship examines ethical concerns such as bias and fairness in algorithmic systems (Hancock et al., 2020; van den Broek et al., 2026).

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Much of this research focuses on how algorithms can either mitigate or reproduce biases in human–AI collaboration, whether through training on incomplete or skewed datasets or through design decisions that embed the perspectives of their developers. Extending this line of inquiry, van den Broek et al. (2026) show that fairness in AI-assisted hiring does not arise solely from algorithmic optimisation but from the growing symbiosis between HR professionals and AI procedures. Beyond bias and fairness, Kellogg et al. (2020) review a range of employment-related concerns associated with algorithmic management, including loss of privacy when employers collect data that is not directly relevant to work tasks and problems of data accuracy, where employees lack visibility into what information is gathered and therefore have limited ability to challenge erroneous assessments.

Overarching Observations from the Literature Review

The research on AI in organizations now spans multiple levels of analysis and touches nearly every subfield of management and organization studies. This breadth reflects the extraordinary speed with which AI has become a focal concern across the field and calls for greater collaboration across traditionally siloed sub-disciplines and closer connection between studies examining different levels of analysis (Hillebrand et al., 2025).

A clear pattern emerging from the literature is its strong conceptual orientation relative to empirical work. This conceptual emphasis is understandable: scholars are rebuilding their theoretical tools while trying to anticipate how AI may reshape core organizational assumptions. Some major puzzling questions in this area are related to the difficulty of keeping pace with a technology that evolves rapidly, is unevenly adopted across organizational settings, and often remains opaque even to its designers. Although empirical work in this *Special Issue* and elsewhere is beginning to address these puzzles, managers, professionals, and researchers alike confront AI as a moving target. As technological capabilities expand, many organizations are still struggling to understand what these systems can do. This dynamism also complicates scholarly inquiry, given our reliance on empirical observation and interpretive distance.

A further challenge in this fast emerging literature is that 'AI' is often invoked without specifying what technological form is under examination. The term can refer to any number of families of techniques (Benbya et al., 2021) that differ substantially in their architectures, data dependencies, and modes of functioning. Even when technological materiality is addressed, AI's inherent opacity limits the extent to which any observer–researcher, manager, or developer – can fully account for why a model behaves as it does. These characteristics distinguish AI from many prior technologies in management studies and call for more nuanced theorizing capable of capturing its distinctive effects. Future research should explore the organizational implications of different AI systems more rigorously and systematically.

Together, these issues point to a deeper conceptual difficulty. Grouping diverse systems under the singular label 'artificial intelligence' often obscures more than it clarifies. Technologies that operate through fundamentally different logics – predictive, generative, agentic or embodied – are frequently treated as a unified category,

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complicating theoretical development and contributing to empirical fragmentation. To address this challenge, we next develop a framework that conceptualizes AI as a fluid frontier of computational capability, offering greater analytical precision in distinguishing among contemporary forms and clarifying their organizational consequences.

THE FLUID FRONTIER: AI AS A CONCEPTUAL MOVING TARGET

A central challenge for organizational research on artificial intelligence is that the phenomenon itself is in continual flux. As Berente et al. (2021) argue, AI is better understood as a shifting frontier of computational capability than as a single, stable technological object (Stelmaszak et al., 2026). What counted as 'AI' only a few years ago – predominantly predictive systems designed to classify, rank or optimize – differs markedly from the generative, reasoning and increasingly embodied systems entering organizational contexts today (though they certainly overlap, and are perhaps used in tandem). This instability creates a mismatch between the technologies being deployed in practice and the categories we rely upon to theorize them. Treating these heterogeneous systems as if they belonged to one class risks flattening their distinct affordances and helps explain the conceptual and empirical fragmentation noted in our review. As Huysman (2026) notes, it is difficult to reach a deep understanding of AI at work and organizations without paying attention to the distinct material elements of each specific AI technology and how those shape – and are shaped – through their interactions with humans.

To move beyond this flattening, we distinguish several modes of AI, each operating through different logics and generating different organizational consequences. These modes co-exist in practice but are analytically separable (see Table I), helping to illuminate why studies of 'AI' often produce divergent or even contradictory findings.

Predictive AI

The first mode, and the one most extensively examined in early organizational scholarship, is predictive and extractive AI. These systems rely on pattern recognition to forecast outcomes, classify entities, or detect anomalies in large datasets. Research in this area has shown how predictive models generate new forms of anticipatory quantification (Faraj et al., 2018) and unsettle established forms of professional expertise. Lebovitz et al. (2022), for instance, demonstrate how radiologists navigate tensions between algorithmic probability scores and embodied diagnostic judgment. In professional service firms, extractive systems that scan contracts or regulatory documents prompt new forms of jurisdictional negotiation, as practitioners cede routine analytical tasks while seeking to maintain interpretive authority (Faulconbridge et al., 2025). Across these settings, the dominant organizational tensions centre on opacity, surveillance, and the redistribution of cognitive labour within organizations.

Generative AI

A second and more recent mode is generative AI. These systems generate synthetic text, images, code and other multimodal artefacts, shifting attention from the analysis of existing data to the creation of new material. Grimes et al. (2023) characterize this as

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Table I. Modes of contemporary AI and their organizational implications

Mode of AI	*Core capabilities*	*Representative systems*	*Diffusion level*	*Distinctive affordances*	*Organizational implications*
Predictive AI	Pattern recognition, forecasting, classification, anomaly detection, large-scale data extraction	Relativity, Kira Systems, radiology classifiers, fraud detection systems	Widely diffused	Scalable pattern recognition; high-volume extraction; efficiency in routine analysis	Redistribution of expertise; expansion of surveillance and monitoring; opacity and interpretability tensions; jurisdictional renegotiation in professional work (Faraj et al., 2018; Lebovitz et al., 2022; Pachidi et al., 2021)
Generative AI	Synthetic production of text, images, code, audio, multimodal artefacts	GPT-5 0.1, Midjourney v6, Stable Diffusion XL, GitHub Copilot	Substantially diffused	Content abundance; computer programming; lowered creative and analytical barriers	Shift from production to curation; heightened verification and evaluative labour; challenges to authorship, originality and professional identity (Doshi and Hauser, 2024; Grimes et al., 2023; Susarla et al., 2023)
Agentic AI	Multi-step reasoning, task decomposition, tool use, autonomous sequencing of tasks	AutoGen, LangChain agents, MM-Agent (research), OctoTools (research)	Emerging adoption	Partial autonomy; orchestration across tools; simulation of cognitive workflows	Challenges to cognitive sovereignty; new accountability and governance architectures; hybrid human–AI reasoning systems; reconfiguration of authority in decision-making (Humberd and Latham, 2026; Leonardi, 2025)
Embodied AI	Physical manipulation, mobility, perception integrated with cognitive controllers (i.e., LLMs)	Tesla Optimus (prototype), Agility Robotics Digit (pilots), Sanctuary AI Phoenix (lab), Apptronik Apollo (pilots), 1X EVE (pilots)	Prototype / lab-stage	Physical task execution; embodied coordination; material presence in work environments	Labour substitution in physical roles; safety, compliance and liability concerns; reorganization of material workflows; transformation of spatial, sensory and affective dimensions of work (Liu et al., 2025; Sawik et al., 2023; Shibata and Wada, 2011)

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a transition from knowledge scarcity to knowledge abundance, raising questions about authorship, authenticity and verification. The labour market implications are already visible. Hui et al. (2024) show that generative tools reduced demand for freelance workers in creative and writing-intensive domains. Boussioux et al. (2024) meanwhile demonstrate that AI-augmented ideation can improve output quality, though this is tempered by Doshi and Hauser's (2024) findings that these tools may also induce conceptual convergence as models reproduce dominant patterns contained in their training data. Kulkarni et al. (2024) and Susarla et al. (2023) highlight the epistemic risks associated with hallucinations, which necessitate new forms of evaluative work to assess the credibility of machine-generated content. Organisationally, generative systems reshape how knowledge is produced, valued and verified. In many workplaces, generative AI is likely to have a structural impact as it makes many established job roles redundant, forcing a change to the shape of organizations.

Agentic AI

A third, still emerging mode involves reasoning and agentic AI. These systems go beyond the generation of artefacts and begin to participate in more structured forms of problem solving. They can break down tasks, invoke external tools such as search functions or code execution environments, retrieve information, and construct multi-step analyses. Early demonstrations suggest that such systems can already perform components of research and analytical work when integrated with external toolkits (Korinek, 2023). Empirical studies also show that as reasoning-capable systems enter professional domains, they begin to influence how problems are framed and how judgment is exercised. For example, Krakowski et al. (2023) document how AI participates in hybrid problem-solving arrangements, altering interpretive processes and shifting the locus of evaluative authority. Similarly, Lebovitz et al. (2022) show how professionals negotiate responsibility and expertise when algorithmic systems contribute to the reasoning underpinning diagnostic decisions. Across these settings, AI systems are likely to shape not only the execution of tasks but also the cognitive scaffolding through which work is organized.

The organizational tensions in this mode revolve around cognitive sovereignty, accountability, and the division of labour in decision-making. Prior work on algorithmic systems highlights how black-box reasoning introduces new ambiguities in responsibility allocation (Anthony, 2021), and how decision architectures shift when professionals rely on machine-structured analytic pathways rather than their own experiential judgment (Lebovitz et al., 2022). Studies of human–AI collaboration further show that as systems undertake more interpretive work, professionals must renegotiate their epistemic roles, either deferring to or overriding machine-generated reasoning depending on contextual cues, trust, and perceived reliability (He et al., 2026; Jago, 2019; Waardenburg et al., 2022). These dynamics underscore a central tension: as AI assumes greater involvement in reasoning processes, the boundaries of human authority become less stable and more contested, raising concerns around the future of work once agentic AI becomes widely implemented.

A further conceptual issue concerns the meaning of agency itself. Organization scholars generally interpret agency in relational or sociomaterial terms, focusing on

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how technologies become entangled in distributed action and hybrid forms of knowing (Orlikowski, 2007; Leonardi, 2011; Gehman et al., 2025). Practitioners and engineers, in contrast, use 'agentic' more instrumentally to describe systems that initiate and sequence tasks, interact with tools, adapt to contingencies, and operate with partial autonomy. While these interpretations have historically remained distinct, recent systems increasingly bring them together. Recognizing this convergence is essential for theoretical accounts (Jones, 2025; Leonardi, 2025) that seek to remain aligned with contemporary AI capabilities and to anticipate how reasoning and agentic systems may reshape organizational cognition.

Embodied AI

A final, and still comparatively underdeveloped, mode concerns embodied AI. This refers to the integration of computational intelligence with physical form. In contrast to the rapid maturation of generative and reasoning systems, embodied AI has diffused more slowly into organizational settings, which partly explains its limited treatment in management and organization studies to date. Yet the technological frontier is advancing quickly. Contemporary humanoid and mobile robotic systems, including Tesla's Optimus, Figure 02, Agility Robotics' Digit, Sanctuary AI's Phoenix, Boston Dynamics' Atlas and Spot, Apptronik's Apollo and 1X Technologies' EVE, now exhibit levels of dexterity, environmental awareness and task adaptability that would have been almost unthinkable a decade ago. Recent work uses LLMs as high-level controllers for robots, allowing AI systems that reason in natural language to directly guide physical action. This brings digital and embodied forms of AI into much closer alignment, with profound implications for organization and management.

Demographic projections suggest that embodied AI may become central to organizational life sooner than anticipated. OECD and UN analyses repeatedly highlight ageing populations and severe labour shortages in care work, healthcare logistics, agriculture and various service domains. Academic and Policy documents increasingly anticipate robotic augmentation in these sectors (Liu et al., 2025; OECD, 2025), and early deployments, such as therapeutic robots like PARO (Shibata and Wada, 2011), provide a glimpse of future activity. Mobile robotic assistants in long-term care facilities (Sawik et al., 2023) demonstrate that embodied AI is already shifting from R&D into practice. The organizational tensions associated with this mode concern material coordination, physical safety, emotional labour and the lived experience of working alongside autonomous machines (and the potential decline in human contact and happiness). As embodied AI systems become more capable, they are likely to reshape not only workflow design but also the sensory, spatial and affective dimensions of organizational life. Accordingly, we anticipate that embodied AI will become one of the most significant areas of organizational research in the coming decade as societies confront the radical implications of near zero-marginal-cost physical labour.

The Value of Differentiating AI Modes

Differentiating these modes clarifies why organizational studies of AI often produce heterogeneous and occasionally conflicting findings. Each mode operates through a distinct

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logic, produces a different set of organizational affordances, and invites its own theoretical questions. Treating AI as a moving frontier of capability, rather than as a single, unified construct, therefore offers a more analytically precise foundation for interpreting the contributions in this *Special Issue*. It also supports the development of a research agenda that can remain responsive to the rapid, uneven, and ongoing evolution of contemporary AI systems.

CONTRIBUTIONS OF THE SPECIAL ISSUE

Developed over a period of technological change of unprecedented pace, 14 papers in this special issue help establish a better understanding of the possibilities and challenges afforded by (mainly) predictive AI to managers and organizations, and offer theoretically and methodologically generative frameworks and approaches that inform current and future research. We outline the key contributions of each paper next.

Conceptualizing and Approaching AI in Management Studies

The first two papers advance understanding of how to conceptualize and approach AI in organizational and management research. First, our editorial is followed by an invited essay. Taking into account management scholars' race with making sense of how AI's fast-paced developments affect organizations, we invited a scholar with a long history in studying technology in organizations to share their experiences from studying AI in organizations since before it became a hype. In her essay, Huysman (2026) raises the challenges of trying to address AI in organizations from a technological deterministic approach and urges management scholars to pay more conceptual and empirical attention to AI by trying to understand its relational character. By bringing examples from the AI@Work research group's research on AI development and its use at work and organizations, Huysman unpacks how the ontological assumptions and paradigmatic approaches of the relational perspective (Anthony et al., 2023; Bailey et al., 2022; Scott and Orlikowski, 2022) can shed light on the emergent and often unexpected impacts that arise as organizations and AI mutually shape each other.

Stelmaszak et al. (2026)'s conceptual paper is well aligned with Huysman's (2026) emphasis on the relational perspective, offering a distinct theoretical contribution by reconceptualizing AI. The authors argue that to realize the potential of the relational perspective, scholars need to move beyond viewing AI as a tool or independent actor toward viewing AI as part of a system of work, which acknowledges the mutual production of actors as they interact in practice. Drawing on posthumanism (Barad, 2003; Gherardi, 2022), the authors suggest an ontological shift from AI as an entity to AI as an organizational capability. Such a capability emerges through the complex interactions and relations among multiple human and algorithmic actors.

Evolving Role and Impact of AI in the Workplace

We have six papers that explore the evolving role and impact of AI in the workplace from different perspectives. Mayer et al. (2026) give us a rich account of how expert authority relations and interactions are reconfigured when AI is introduced in the workplace. As

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AI becomes increasingly used to automate decisions, professionals often find themselves having limited to no power to override a decision outcome, even though they still need to communicate and explain it to their clients. Faced with often inscrutable insights, experts thus risk losing their authority. Mayer et al. draw on a comparative field study in banking, biotechnology, and recruitment to analyse the different explaining practices that experts perform in order to make clients understand and accept the AI decisions while also trying to maintain their expert authority. The comparison enabled the authors to identify the relational conditions that shaped these practices, including whether clients considered professionals' expertise as unique or whether the interactions between experts and clients allowed the experts to learn from their clients' evolving needs and adapt their explaining practices accordingly.

Next, using the context of corporate credit-rating, Lee et al. (2026) explore the mechanisms of individual reliance on AI advice and ultimately their decision performance in terms of decision accuracy. Drawing from the integrative theory of anchoring (Simmons et al., 2010) and literature on judge-advisor systems (Chacon et al., 2022), a set of longitudinal experimental studies found that differences between individuals' initial estimates and AI advice (i.e., user-AI differences) reduced over time. Among other results, this study found that greater user-AI differences made individuals more likely to revise their initial judgments, although they exhibited lower relative dependence on AI advice. This study explains a nuanced perspective on AI-assisted decision-making, showing how individual attitudes toward algorithmic advice may change over time.

Using the context of gig work and following cognitive load theory (Sweller, 1988), Yang et al. (2026) examine the effects of different forms of AI explanations in terms of counterfactual (i.e., alternatives that could have resulted in different outcomes) versus factual (i.e., explanations on what in fact happened) and local (i.e., explanations on individual instances) versus global (i.e., accounts of overall logic behind AI decisions) on acceptance of AI-based decisions and relations with platform management in terms of trust, understanding, and fairness. Their experimental study confirmed that individually, both counterfactual and local explanations significantly improved the acceptance of AI decisions, but when combined, they eroded this acceptance. They also found that the acceptance of AI decisions was the underlying mechanism of the effects of different types of explanations on platform management relations. This study shows the importance of cognitive load in how gig workers process platform information with significant implications for their acceptance of AI decisions and ultimately their relations with platform management.

Building on the preceding discussion of evolving authority relations, Vuori et al. (2026) examine how organizational members develop emotional and cognitive trust in AI, and how these trust configurations shape their behavioural responses to algorithmic evaluation. They showed that trust dynamics influence not only whether individuals accept AI recommendations, but also how they strategically adapt their behaviour in anticipation of algorithmic judgment, altering patterns of digital engagement to manage perceived exposure. These anticipatory adjustments, in turn, feed back into the AI's behavioural predictions, revealing a recursive process in which human interpretations of AI agency actively reshape the system's outputs. Conceptually, the study underscores that the legitimacy of algorithmic authority emerges relationally rather than technologically, aligning

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with our broader argument that the organizational consequences of agentic and predictive AI depend on the emotional, cognitive, and behavioural responses they elicit from humans.

In another set of experimental studies and combining the insights of theories of planned behaviour (Ajzen, 1991) and social presence (Short et al., 1976), Siemon et al. (2026) explore the effects of presence on motivation to contribute via willingness to depend on others and team-oriented commitment in the setting of online collaborative ideation. They found that social presence significantly enhanced motivation to contribute, both in human only and human–AI teams. Both willingness to depend on others and team-oriented commitment explained this effect. This study shows how an AI teammate can take on a role of an autonomous agent, which can significantly foster team collaboration. This study argues that, unlike anthropomorphising AI to improve human–AI collaboration, it is the transparency and clear explanation of AI's role as a teammate that matters for successful human–AI collaboration.

Finally, Schulz et al. (2026) explore the relationship between AI adoption and employee job satisfaction following job characteristics theory (Hackman and Oldham, 1976). Using longitudinal data of US publicly listed companies comprising multiple datasets and 10 follow-up interviews with managers working in these companies, they found an inverted U-shaped relationship between firms' AI adoption and employee job satisfaction, with employees working for higher exploration-orientation firms maintaining their job satisfaction for longer despite their firms increasing AI adoption. Employees who worked in firms with higher levels of data governance experienced more stable job satisfaction. This study shows that the adoption of AI can have both enrichment and impairment effects on employee satisfaction, and these can be explained by job complexity and autonomy.

AI's Implications for Strategic Management

Our collection includes three papers on AI's implications for strategic management. Hudson and Morgan (2026) extend themes raised in earlier workplace-focused contributions by shifting attention to the organizational level, demonstrating that AI reshapes not only workers' experiences but also firms' strategic risk landscapes. They show that firms in AI-exposed industries face elevated idiosyncratic risk and that heterogeneous board networks help mitigate this uncertainty. This highlights how governance capabilities become critical in navigating AI-driven technological change.

Using real options theory (Myers, 1977), Li et al. (2026) advance the concept of AI specialization as a source of technological and competitive benefits to predict that firms with higher levels of AI specialization capitalize on their internal expertise to pursue growth opportunities by means of acquisition of AI firms. They confirmed this prediction and also found that technical, modal, and complementarity uncertainty acted as boundary conditions for the relationship between a firm's AI specialization and its acquisition of AI firms. This study shows how firms with greater technological knowledge are more likely to identify strategic opportunities for AI acquisition to further strengthen their current capabilities.

Humberd and Latham (2026) extend this conversation by examining how AI evolves from a programmable tool into an organizational agent, drawing on agency theory to show how delegation to increasingly autonomous systems reshapes responsibility, monitoring, and

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control. Their analysis illustrates how AI begins to occupy an ambiguous agent-like role within governance structures, raising novel agency problems and challenging assumptions about alignment and accountability. Conceptually, their work resonates strongly with our discussion of agentic AI, highlighting how organizational theories must adapt as AI systems move beyond prediction or generation to participate actively in decision architectures.

AI for Entrepreneurship

One article from the special issue dives into AI for entrepreneurship. Ramoglou et al. (2026) provide a conceptual analysis that fundamentally challenges and reshapes how entrepreneurship scholars may reconsider the central knowledge problem of entrepreneurship (Townsend et al., 2018). They argue that Knightian uncertainty is radicalized in the GenAI era: the multiplicity of ideas enabled by Generative AI shifts the focus from individual entrepreneurs' creativity toward the risks associated with AI-generated ideas, bringing to the fore a 'grand epistemological challenge'. To address this challenge, the authors draw on Gigerenzer's (2015) theory of effective decision-making under uncertainty, which shifts attention from the pursuit of certainty to models of adaptive navigation that involve decision strategies attuned to the structure of the decision environment. Through their analysis, Ramoglou et al. (2026) develop an ecological model of opportunity search, which is grounded on a symbiotic relationship between humans and AI. Their model suggests that while AI allows for the expansion of the ideation space, humans may contract the range of entrepreneurial opportunities considered by assessing the realism of the AI-generated ideas.

Ethical Implications of AI

We also have one article that dives deeply into ethical considerations of AI for leadership. He et al. (2026) contribute to the field of leadership by examining the ethical challenges that arise when leaders manage human–AI collaborations. Using a four-study design and drawing on moral relativism (Harman, 1975), they develop and test a model suggesting that when leaders manage human–AI collaboration, they are likely to be exposed to diverse moral codes and, by consequence, adopt situated moral judgments as an adaptive response and may, by consequence, engage in unethical behaviour at work. The model also suggests that leaders' need for cognitive closure may negatively moderate these effects. The study contributes to research on human–AI collaboration by advancing a leader-centric perspective and unpacking how engagement with AI technologies may shape leaders' ethical perceptions and may even lead to unethical behaviour.

Coming Full Circle

The special issue is wrapped up by Ramaul et al. (2026), who take a different tack by interrogating the conceptual foundations that underpin much organizational scholarship on AI. Their problematizing review shows how prevailing lenses of rationality and anthropomorphism risk mischaracterizing AI as either an idealized optimiser or a quasi-human actor, thereby obscuring the relational and sociomaterial processes through which

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AI's organizational effects actually unfold. By reframing AI not as a bounded entity but as an evolving assemblage of human practices, data infrastructures, and algorithmic behaviours, the authors open space for more grounded theorizing that better reflects how AI reconfigures organizational life in practice.

Taken together, the papers in this special issue show just how far the field has come in trying to understand what AI means for organizations today. Across different methods, settings, and theories, they demonstrate that AI does not exert its influence in isolation. Instead, its effects take shape through shifting relationships between people, data, organizational routines, and institutional expectations. Several papers illuminate how expertise and authority are being reworked as professionals learn to navigate algorithmic decisions. Others point to the ways in which strategy, judgment, and entrepreneurial action are being reoriented in environments defined by rapid technological change and growing uncertainty. What links these contributions is a shared recognition that AI is altering not only what organizations do, but how they come to know, decide, and act.

These insights provide a strong foundation for what follows. In the next section, we outline a research agenda that builds on these themes and identifies the conceptual, methodological, and ethical questions that deserve sustained attention as AI continues to evolve.

RESEARCH AGENDA

The 14 conceptual, review and empirical works comprising this *Special Issue* constitute an impressive collection of contributions and insights concerning the organizational and managerial impacts of AI, but these articles also serve as a stark reminder of how far we have yet to go – as scholars and as a society – to understand AI's broad and deep integration into our daily lives. The sheer speed of AI-driven technological change is both exciting and unsettling, as is the close proximity of our vantage point, which simultaneously places scholars close to the action, but with few tools to historically, psychologically, sociologically, economically, politically, or organizationally situate AI's technosocial impacts (Hagerty and Rubinov, 2019). The editors of this *Special Issue* are acutely aware of the fact that we are introducing this collection of AI research just 3 years after the initial launch of ChatGPT. The likelihood of being wrong about both the vector and velocity of AI vastly exceeds the likelihood of being right, but it rests upon the shoulders of management scholars to move beyond the question of *what AI can do*, in order to address the far more critical question of how AI's transformative impacts can be understood and channeled toward human-machine ensembles (Rady et al., 2026) that serve the common good (see also Huysman (2026) in this special issue).

The ontological nature of this quest is unmistakable, as are the most pressing questions, including the following: How does AI reshape agency, authority, and expertise? How do organizations manage algorithmic collectives and agentic systems? How do societies maintain diversity, variance, and resilience in algorithmically optimized environments? How do institutional logics adapt to a world in which AI participates

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in rulemaking and value creation? And, directly to the heart of organizational and management theory: What is the interpretive capacity of existing theories to make sense of AI, and where is there a need for reassessment and revision? Considerable technological and intellectual momentum supports the assertion that AI systems will soon occupy positions of epistemic authority (Alonso and Câmara, 2024; Lindebaum et al., 2024; Zhu et al., 2020). In many respects, this is already the case insofar as such systems now routinely outperform managers in forecasting, risk assessment, diagnostic classification, and other complex tasks that lie well beyond the calculative powers of humans (Agrawal et al., 2018; Jarrahi, 2018). The delegation of epistemic authority to algorithmic tools fundamentally redistributes organizational agency in a fashion that tests the efficacy of the OMT canon. When AI systems are delegated actor-like status and possess the capacity not only to influence decisions but also to take action, then there is reason to believe that concepts such as 'augmentation' or 'support' are woefully inadequate.

Most organizational theories rest upon the assumption that decisions, actions, and outcomes are the consequence of human agency. Even scholarship on sociomateriality ultimately places human interpretation and enactment at its centre (Leonardi, 2012; Orlikowski, 2007; Orlikowski and Scott, 2008). AI challenges this ontological anchor when algorithmic tools play a broad and deep epistemic function through the identification of patterns, the issuance of recommendations, and the ability to make autonomous decisions. When these things occur, the boundaries between machine-actors and human-actors become ambiguous, and often quite porous. This, in turn, raises fundamental questions regarding the central purpose of humans and their organizations, including: How do social attributions of intention, blame, and responsibility shift when decision architectures are hybrid human–AI systems? Under what conditions do algorithmic predictions acquire normative force, becoming not merely descriptive but prescriptive? How do organizations legitimize – or de-legitimatize – computational agency?

Confronted by this litany of exciting and troubling questions, the articles in this Special Issue, as well as the many outstanding contributions recently published in other leading journals, represent only the tip of the iceberg of all that is to come in AI-related research. The limited nature of this purview is not a criticism, but simply a sign of the times; the reality that comes with seeking to address turbulent times without the benefit of some distance. While research agenda concerning management and organizations in the Age of AI will be incomplete – and at least some parts of it might appear obsolete or even wrong in the not-too-distant future! – we believe that the next decade will be a watershed period for management and organizational scholars, given their pivotal role in the social sense making of AI. The following six dimensions are prominent examples of the domains in which our field must take a leading role.

AI and the Redistribution of Agency in Organizations

For good reason, OMT has traditionally situated human actors as the locus of judgment, intention, and discretion (March and Olsen, 1976; Scott, 2014), since they have been the clear, unambiguous arbiters of the hierarchical structures, contractual

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arrangements, and relational coordination that characterize the form and function of organizations. AI fundamentally alters this landscape by performing a wide assortment of tasks that previously required human intervention and interpretation, such as identifying anomalies, proposing strategies, triaging information, allocating resources, or monitoring compliance (Seeber et al., 2020; von Krogh, 2018). Ceding these core functions to algorithmic agents raises critical questions concerning the purpose of organizations in the future. In the coming decade, management scholars will need to assess the impacts of AI-mediated coordination, run largely by agentic systems that can function autonomously, including coordination with external entities regarding a wide array of core business activities, including orchestrating workflows, anticipating bottlenecks, and providing real-time decision support (Jarrahi, 2018). Managerial tasks once dependent on human cognitive bandwidth may be filtered, scripted, or automated through algorithmic systems. Through this, traditional firms, powered by human cognition, evolve from hierarchical entities to administrative ecosystems, co-governed by humans and algorithms. Management scholars are uniquely situated to describe and critique the merits and demerits of this evolutionary process, asking: What are the gains and losses due to human-machine hybridity? Which existing and new organizational forms are most conducive to facilitating purposeful AI impacts, while mitigating those that are unwanted? Are we entering a 'post-organizational' era? If so, how can scholars develop multi-level metrics to assess the favourable or unfavourable nature of the impacts? How does AI-mediated authority reshape power dynamics among employees, managers, and executives?

The Algorithmicization of Organizational Routines

Closely related to the redistribution of agency is the impact of algorithmic tools on organizational routines. Existing work in OMT has looked long and hard at the role of explicit and tacit human knowledge in the development and promulgation of efficient, effective systems of value creation. Even theories of dynamic capabilities (e.g., Teece et al., 1997) look to human involvement as a cornerstone of sustainable competitive advantage, yet there is already evidence that organizational routines are rapidly becoming co-evolving processes guided by and co-produced by algorithmic agents and humans (Burford et al., 2021; Doshi et al., 2025; Rady et al., 2026). In the very near future, AI tools will generate their own routines, learning and refining themselves based on organizational data. This use of AI has immense potential for heightened value creation because AI systems have the ability to see the bigger picture – both inside and outside the organization, thereby enabling them to discover and effectuate solutions to suboptimalities through enhanced, cross-agent coordination that is often beyond the comprehension of human-centric analytics. This blend of AI's complexity-cracking ingeniousness and strategic foresight opens new possibilities for the creation and implementation of organizational strategies and tactics. Yet, there are also notable complications that scholars can explore, asking: Under these conditions, who or what owns the routine? How do routines 'remember' past actions when memory is distributed across agents? What maintains routines when AI agents are frequently updated or retrained? Will organizational routines eventually become living

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systems? If so, what would happen if their adaptation, drift, and evolution occur at a pace faster than human governance mechanisms can regulate?

Managerial Cognition in an Age of Algorithmic Abundance

For much of the past 8 years, management and organizational scholars have sought to explain when and how individuals and organizations contend with information scarcity, attentional limits, and cognitive constraints (March, 1994; Simon, 1947). Generative AI, and particularly the proliferation of increasingly remarkable LLMs, completely reverses this logic (Hunt et al., 2025). Already, organizations face an overabundance, not a paucity, of information. In the nearly three decades since Deep Blue beat Gary Kasparov, AI tools have completely outstripped even the most sophisticated human capacity to predict, simulate, and prescribe alternate scenarios (Agrawal et al., 2018; Townsend and Hunt, 2019). As a result, humans increasingly find themselves engaged in idea curation, rather than idea generation. For scholars, this raises an important question: What happens when managers face interpretive overload? And, given the extent to which individuals will be forced to adjudicate between competing algorithmic outputs, assess reliability, and override machine-optimal recommendations (Townsend et al., 2025), how will this new source of cognitive asymmetry be addressed? Are there new opportunities for managers who can handle interpretive uncertainties? Can organizations develop human capital capable of overseeing the interaction between human reasoning and distributed algorithmic cognition? How will organizations handle the transition from a focus on personal expertise to the governance of heterogeneous intelligences?

AI-Driven Involution: Organizational Intensification Without Advancement

Side-by-side with algorithmic abundance is the looming spectre of AI-driven involution. 'Involution' is a term from anthropological and agrarian studies (Geertz, 1963), and more recently in the study of digital labor and educational competition in China (e.g., Neff, 2012), that describes conditions in which activities become increasingly elaborate, competitive, and self-reinforcing, but with the paradoxical result of also becoming static, stagnant, utterly imitative, and often self-defeating to the intended benefits. AI has the potential to dramatically escalate the speed and extent of involution by intentionally reducing variance and homogenizing processes through AI's focus on developing and pursuing optimization aims (Hunt and Kurdoglu, 2025) that institute round after round of monitoring, prediction, evaluation, and comparison, followed by unending cycles of fine-tuning. While this seems like a good formula for the maximization of system-wide efficiency and effectiveness, involution is anathema to adaptive capacity, variance-generating mutations, and true innovation (Doshi and Hauser, 2024; Hunt and Kurdoglu, 2025). For scholars of entrepreneurship, strategy, innovation, and creativity, AI-driven involution demands a deep reconsideration of how organizations can implement safeguards against the variance-destroying facets of AI tools while still harvesting the efficiency improvements that are critical for maintaining competitive parity (Townsend et al., 2025; Townsend and Hunt, 2019). It is critical for scholars to explore these emerging tensions by asking: What are the causes and consequences of algorithmic convergence in strategic decision-making

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and marketplace actions? Can organizations deploy heterodox models and deliberately 'noisy' AI systems to explore variant approaches in order to preserve key sources of innovation and differentiation?

The Transformation of Work and its Meaning

Long before the emergence of generative AI, management scholars have been at the forefront of efforts to understand the changing nature of work (Chalmers et al., 2021). Digital technologies have had a tectonic impact on the traditional social arrangements of work and the workplace (Hunt et al., 2025) – perhaps more so than at any time since the shift from an agrarian-dominant to an industry-dominant workforce. As great as those impacts have been, it is likely that AI will challenge professional identity and occupational legitimacy in even more fundamental ways. Some facets of these changes will be democratizing, with a 'world-flattening' influence (Friedman, 2005), such as an erosion in traditional forces that historically sustained knowledge asymmetries between individuals and among entities, controlled access to specialized expertise, and fortified restrictive professional norms and occupational gatekeeping. Such changes could have a liberating effect on actors' ability to pursue varied employment opportunities in a less encumbered fashion. Other consequences of AI's integration into the DNA of organizations may be far less sanguine, evidenced by a loss of occupational identity and organizational connectedness. Scholars can provide important insights through research that draws attention to and an understanding of the opportunities and threats attendant to the integration of AI in the workplace. How does it facilitate or impede the meaningfulness of work? How do professional identities shape receptivity to AI-mediated authority?

Organizational Governance and Power in the Algorithmic Era

The implicit or explicit delegation of decisional authority to algorithmic tools is a source of tremendous controversy. However, it may also be a foregone conclusion, given the rapid adoption of AI for increasingly potent forms of decision-making tasks. While neither the valorization nor the vilification of AI is a useful stance for adjudicating the relative merits and demerits of AI, issues involving organizational governance are a particularly sensitive area of debate since there are understandable concerns attendant to endowing machines with decisional capabilities. Management and organizational scholars have the potential to diffuse hyperbolic claims by providing productive insights and social sense making of issues lying at the heart of concerns regarding power, legitimacy, and organizational control. Already, there is evidence that AI changes who has power, how power is exercised, and what governance means, yet the means by which this is occurring is often opaque. This has, in turn, resulted in ethical concerns about the roles and impacts of algorithmic agents, especially when managers delegate decisional authority that cannot be fully explained or replicated (Chalmers et al., 2021; Hagerty and Rubinov, 2019). Future research will need to address a number of key questions, including: How do organizations manage responsibility when the locus of authority is non-human? What new governance structures are needed to assess and assign responsibility to delegated algorithmic decisions? How does AI delegation influence trust, issue escalation, error correction, and overall

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accountability? When and how might organizations use algorithms as scapegoats or legitimacy shields, much as they do now with government policies? Under what conditions do humans override, versus defer to, AI authority? How does computational legitimacy interact with existing institutional logics? What governance mechanisms can ensure democratic control over algorithmic authority?

CONCLUSION

This article opened by recognizing that AI is developing at a pace that challenges our ability to make sense of it. The contributions collected in this *Special Issue* show why: different forms of AI are altering organizational life in diverse and unprecedented ways that resist simple categorisation. Looking forward, the priority for organizational and management scholarship is becoming clear. We need sharper concepts, more precise accounts of the technological systems we are studying, and empirical work that is able to capture how agency, expertise and coordination evolve as AI capabilities expand (most likely into embodied forms). If AI is indeed redefining the conditions under which organizations operate, then our theories must adapt with equal decisiveness.

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AI USAGE STATEMENT

The authors used generative artificial intelligence tools (Open AI's Chat GPT 5.1) in a limited and supportive role during the development of the analytical table outlining four logics of artificial intelligence presented in this editorial. The conceptual categories (predictive, generative, agentic, and embodied AI), theoretical framing, and interpretive judgments underlying this framework were developed inductively by the authors. AI tools were used only to assist exploratory sense making and to surface illustrative examples consistent with these author-defined categories, particularly in areas where organizational research remains emergent. In addition, generative AI tools were used to support limited editorial tasks, including language polishing, improving clarity, and refining sentence structure. All AI-assisted outputs were critically evaluated, cross-checked against source materials, and refined through human judgment. The authors retain full responsibility for the content of the manuscript.

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